



CHAUHAN

Domestic CONCERNS

Spouses seem to be at the centre of action prior to the polls in Uttar Pradesh. Seema Upadhyay and Rajkumari Chauhan are the wives of the two cabinet ministers—Rambir Upadhyay and Jaibir Bhadauria respectively. While Seema is the BSP's candidate from Fatehpur Sikri, Rajkumari will be contesting from the Aligarh constituency. Obviously the offices of the two ministers who hold important portfolios are virtually paralysed as they are not only campaigning in constituencies of their wives, but also working day and night to ensure their victory. The Opposition has alleged misuse of state machinery in the two constituencies in favour of the BSP candidates, but no one is listening.

by Subhash Mishra

17 women candidates are contesting the Lok Sabha elections in Delhi which has 49 lakh women voters.

Richest Pickings

Rich and flaunting it, Punjab leads the way in the upcoming polls. All 26 candidates from the three major political parties—the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), Congress and BJP—are rolling in money. The average assets per candidate for each party: the BJP (Rs 17.2 crore), the Congress (Rs 9.6 crore) and the SAD (Rs 9.1 crore). The crorepati list is headed by Harsimrat Kaur (SAD) with over Rs 60 crore in total assets, followed by Preneet Kaur (Congress) with assets worth Rs 42 crore. However, when it comes to education, the state cannot boast of an attractive record. Out of a total of 218 candidates, only 128 have studied till Class 12. Surprisingly, 27 of them did not even mention their qualification.

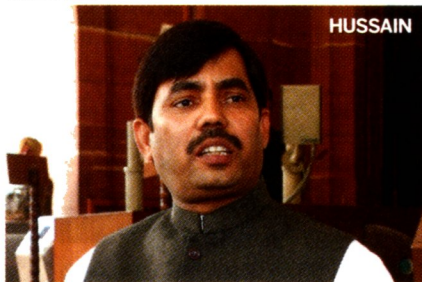
by Arvind Chhabra

HARSIMRAT KAUR



PRABHUJOT GILL

HEMANT CHAWLA



HUSSAIN

Man of Letters

When BJP leader Syed Shahnawaz Hussain thought of a novel method of campaigning for Jagdish Mukhi, a party candidate from West Delhi, little did he know that it would backfire. His personally signed letters to all Muslim voters praising Mukhi didn't go down too well with the recipients. Penned in Hindi, the letter had several stately Urdu words to describe Mukhi's qualities and achievements. An angry social activist Shabnam Hashmi says that singling out a community for any purpose is unwarranted. Mukhi's stand? "It is just an innovative form of campaigning."

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

FOR OLD Times' Sake

Nitish Kumar has gone on record saying the BJP's L.K. Advani was his choice for prime minister. But recently, the Bihar chief minister triggered speculations with his "Left parties are old friends" comment. He went on to say that there was a convergence of views between him and the Left on various issues like the

NITISH KUMAR



RANJAN RAHI

Indo-US nuclear deal. The comment contradicts Sheila Dikshit's claim that the JD(U) may align with the Congress after the elections. While Nitish has rubbished Dikshit's assertion, his leaning for the Left is said to be mutual after the Communists invited him to join the Third Front. To add to the veering conspiracy theories, Congress General Secretary Rahul Gandhi tacitly appreciated Nitish, adding fuel to the fire. All this is no music to saffron ears who vent their lungs on the issue alleging that the Congress was just trying to confuse the electorate. And just imagine the confusion among the parties.

by Amitabh Srivastava